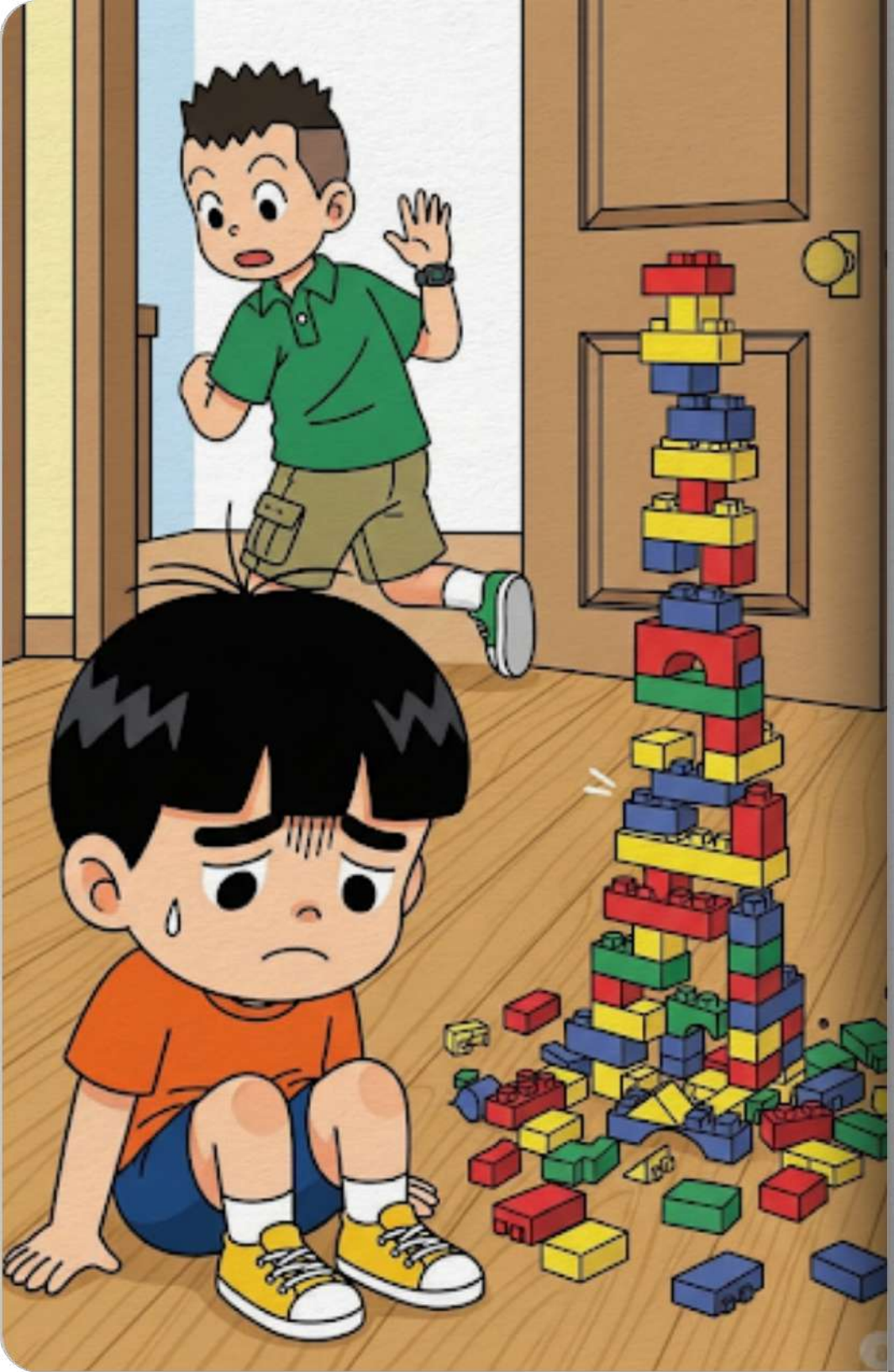
Hiroshi and the Steam-Venting Balloon

By Kshipra

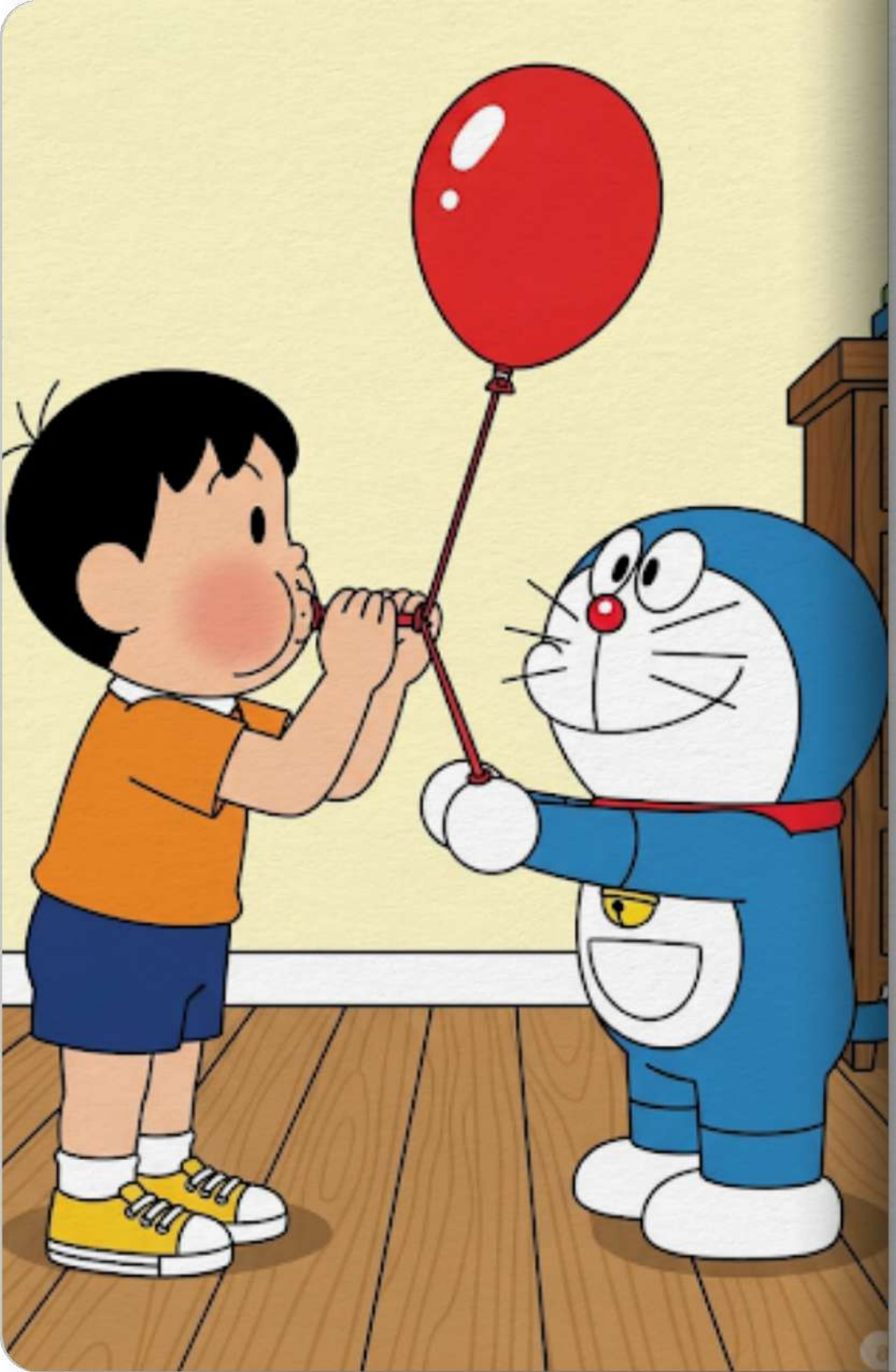


It was a sunny afternoon, but Hiroshi felt like a dark cloud was hovering over his head. He had been building a magnificent tower of blocks for hours, only for Kaito to run past and accidentally knock the whole thing over. Kaito apologized and ran off to play tag, but Hiroshi didn't feel like playing. He felt hot, his heart was thumping like a drum, and his hands were squeezed into tight fists.

Hiroshi stomped his foot so hard the floorboards creaked. He wanted to yell, he wanted to throw his favorite pillow, and he wanted to tell Kaito that he was the meanest person in the world! His face turned as red as a ripe tomato. Every time he thought about his ruined tower, a new wave of heat washed over him. He felt like a tea kettle about to whistle.

Suddenly, a soft whirring sound filled the room. Maru, the round robotic cat from the 22nd century, hopped out of the desk drawer. He saw Hiroshi's red face and the steam practically coming out of his ears. Maru didn't look scared; he looked like he knew exactly what was happening. He reached into his magical four-dimensional belly pouch, searching for something special.

"Anger is like a fire, Hiroshi," Maru said calmly. "If you keep it trapped inside, it burns. If you let it out all at once, it might scorch someone else. You need the 'Steam-Venting Balloon'!" Maru pulled out a small, flat piece of red rubber. It looked like an ordinary balloon, but it had a strange silver dial on the neck and a tiny whistle attached to the top.



"Go ahead," Maru encouraged. "Take a deep breath and blow all that hot, angry air right into the balloon." Hiroshi took a huge breath, puffing out his cheeks. He blew into the balloon with all his might. As he exhaled, he imagined all the "grrr" and "it's not fair" feelings leaving his chest and filling up the red rubber.

The balloon grew bigger and bigger. With every puff, Hiroshi felt his shoulders relax just a little bit. He saw the blocks on the floor, and instead of feeling like he wanted to scream, he just felt a little bit sad. The balloon was now the size of a watermelon, bobbing in the air. Hiroshi tied a knot in the end, feeling much lighter than he did before.

Later that evening, Hiroshi was doing his math homework. He got a very tricky problem wrong three times in a row. He felt that familiar heat rising in his neck again. "I'm no good at this!" he grumbled. He grabbed the balloon and blew into it again. The balloon grew even larger, floating above his head like a giant, grumpy fruit.

The balloon was now so big it hit the ceiling. "Careful!" Maru warned, floating up to check the dial. "When the balloon gets this full, the anger needs to be transformed, or it will pop and turn into a Sour Rain shower that makes everyone grumpy!" Hiroshi looked up at the giant red sphere. He didn't want a Sour Rain shower in his bedroom.

Hiroshi laughed as he popped a bubble. Inside each one was a tiny sound of a joke or a happy memory. Kaito came back into the room, and Hiroshi didn't feel angry anymore. He showed Kaito the bubbles, and they decided to build a new, even bigger tower together. Hiroshi realized that being angry was okay, as long as he knew how to let the steam out before it boiled over.